after assembling 500 to 600 men, the Chinese launched a simultaneous assault on both the Sikh LI night harbour and the Sikh firm base.

Although 1 Sikh, under the charge of Second Lieutenant Surendra Dagur, was at stand-to when the attack came it was taken by surprise and driven out from the firm base. As darkness closed in, the Sikh LI troops fought a resolute defensive battle against the Chinese for nearly two hours. However, owing to the topography, their radio sets were useless and the FOO could not ask for any fire support. Jaspal then gave the order to fall back and the Sikh LI companies performed a reasonably orderly retreat towards the firm base, only to find that it was occupied by waiting Chinese troops instead of their own comrades. In the pandemonium that followed, Lieutenant M. S. Khaira of 2 Sikh LI was killed along with a JCO and fifty-nine other ranks were either killed or went missing. 1 Sikh had two men wounded.

Badly mauled, those who managed to scatter and regroup started reaching the Sikh LI battalion HQ around 11 a.m. By then, another strong patrol had been assembled and was sent out towards the scene of the catastrophe and they returned by last light having collected some of the wounded men.

Kaua had been a massive disaster. It had also created tremendous bad blood between the Sikh LI and Sikh troops, the former feeling terribly let down by the latter. Even before Kaua, there had already been some minor incidents that underlined the tension between the two units, and obviously the coordination between the two left much to be desired. 4 Sikh LI deployed slightly further away in the Two Lakes area was not affected.

While the remnants of the patrol were staggering back, 4 Sikh LI observation posts were reporting a column of more than a thousand Chinese soldiers moving along the Bhutan border along the Chabra-la–Jangle track. All three batteries at Se-la opened fire, but owing to swirling mist and the wooded terrain where the Chinese were, the column quickly disappeared from sight. 4 Garhwal’s Alpha Company that was occupying the forward positions at Nuranang also reported a heavy concentration of Chinese troops across the Tawang Chu. By the evening, the Garhwalis confirmed that there was feverish activity in the vicinity of the Bridge 4 where the demolished bridge was being repaired, the structure having been lit up by vehicle headlights.